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Improving Nurse Confidence Through Unannounced Mock Codes on Inpatient Units

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Improving Nurse Confidence & Preparedness Through Unit-Based Unannounced Mock Codes

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Introduction

Nurses are often the first responders to in-hospital cardiac arrests, yet many report uncertainty about their role and preparedness during these high-stakes events. At Henry Ford Hospital, a baseline survey of inpatient general practice unit nurses revealed gaps in perceived readiness and team communication during code blue situations.



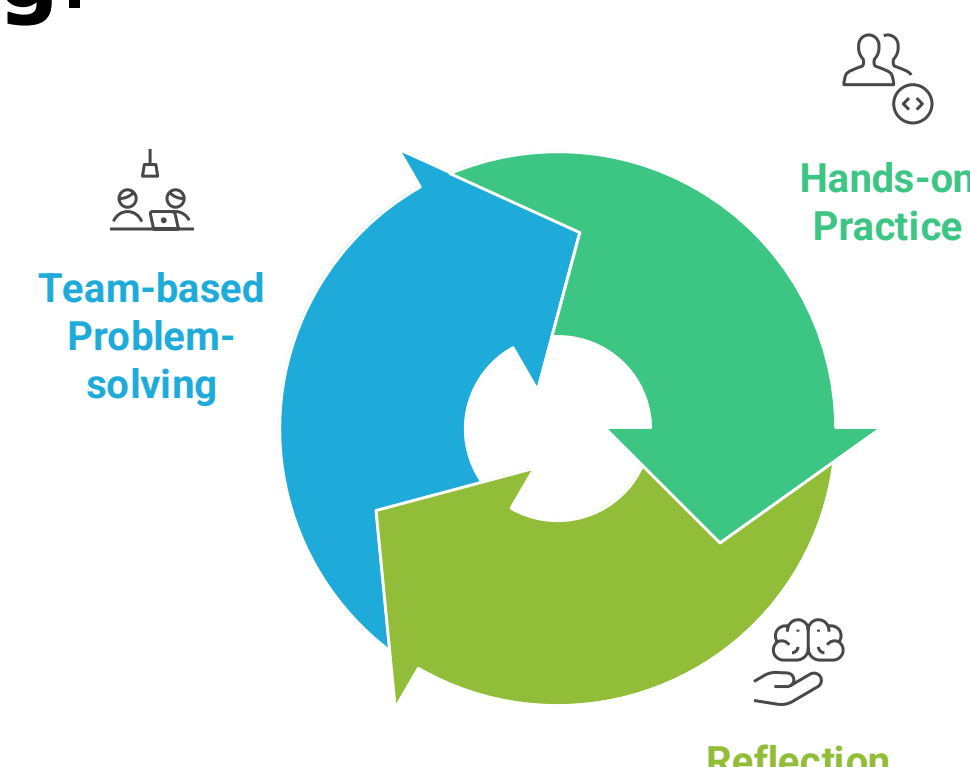
Purpose & Objectives

This quality improvement initiative aims to strengthen nurse confidence, clarify team roles, and promote interdisciplinary communication through the use of unannounced, in situ mock code simulations.

- Increase nurse-reported confidence in code response
- Clarify team roles and foster effective communication
- Use structured debriefing to reinforce learning and identify system-level gaps

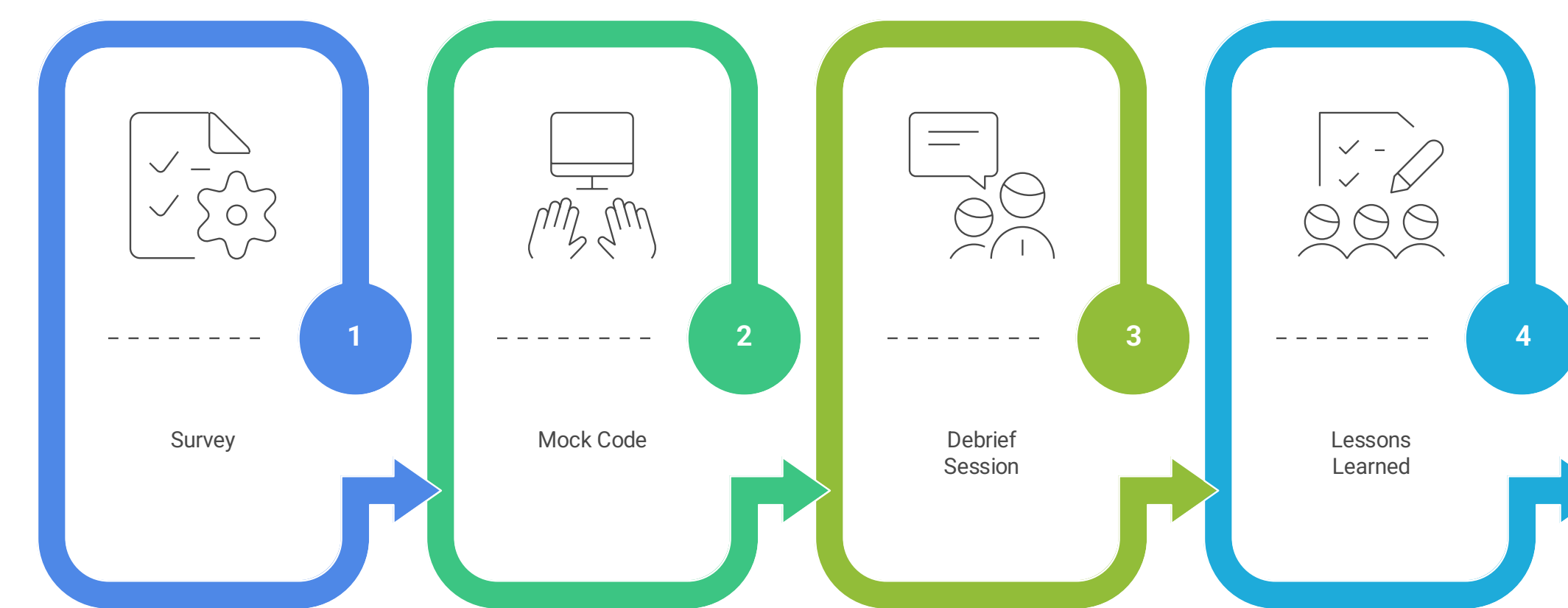
Theoretical Framework

This project is grounded in Kolb's Experiential Learning Theory, prioritizing **hands-on practice**, **reflection**, and **team-based problem-solving**.



Design

A pre-post quality improvement design was used, with all activities embedded in routine professional development.



Setting & Participants

The project took place on select inpatient medical-surgical and surgical specialty units at Henry Ford Hospital. Participants were registered nurses practicing on the designated units.

Intervention

❖ Baseline Survey:

- Nurses completed an anonymous electronic survey (via Microsoft Forms) measuring perceived preparedness, knowledge, and confidence using Likert-scale and open-ended items.

❖ Mock Code Simulations:

- Unannounced, in situ mock code events were conducted in collaboration with nurse managers and educators.
- Each simulation mirrored real-life clinical emergencies and required staff to respond in real time as part of their usual workflow.

❖ Structured Debriefing:

- Immediately after each mock code, facilitators led a structured debrief to reflect on performance, clarify roles, and discuss opportunities for improvement.
- Field notes and debrief summaries were recorded for further analysis.

Anticipated Outcomes

Through repeated, psychologically safe practice and structured feedback, this initiative is expected to:

- Boost nurse confidence in managing code blue situations
- Enhance clarity of team roles and communication
- Surface system-level opportunities for ongoing improvement

Lessons Learned & Risk Assessment

- Nurses appreciated immediate, structured debriefing following mock code events.
- Practicing in a low-risk, team-based environment boosted confidence and preparedness.
- The opportunity to discuss and clarify roles during debriefs was particularly valued.
- Nurses expressed that these simulations allowed them to ask more questions than they would during real events.

What participants said:

"I felt more confident asking questions than in a real code scenario."

"Debriefing right after the event was the most helpful part."

"Practicing in a controlled environment made it less intimidating."

Dissemination & Next Steps

- Results will be shared with nursing leadership and staff to guide unit education and practice.
- Expansion to other units and interdisciplinary teams is under consideration.
- IRB review will be sought if the project advances to formal research.
- For more information or collaboration, contact the project team.